January 2003 and finally sentenced forty-seven policemen to life imprisonment on 4 April 2016, twenty-five years after the incident. By that time, ten of the accused had died and twenty-seven others who had retired from service had gone underground and were not available on the day of the judgment. According to one report, the local police later located six of the missing cops, including Inspector Harpal Singh who was posted as station house officer of Neuria police station at the time of the fake encounter. [3]

During my seven-year tenure as an IPS officer in Uttar Pradesh, I had enjoyed genuine respect from my juniors. I could also observe that Sikhs were never treated as 'outsiders'. In fact, their contribution to the development of the Terai area, of which Pilibhit was a part, was duly appreciated. In an otherwise caste-ridden society, Sikhs were considered to be the sort who 'minded their own business'. In the way that viruses don't recognize territorial boundaries, it appeared that sections of the UP police too were infected by the communal virus. They might have heard stories of their Punjab police counterparts getting out-of-turn promotions, rewards, other benefits and recognition for killing 'terrorists'. But what they forgot was that Uttar Pradesh was not Punjab, where such incidents might be overlooked in the mistaken belief that that doing so would serve the larger interest of bringing peace and stability to a troubled state.

To ascertain how the Punjab Police actually dealt with terrorism during that period, I sought out my batchmate Chaman Lal (IPS 1964 MP). What he told me at the India International Centre on 8 August 2020 is summed up below:

On DGP Punjab K.S. Dhillon's request, Chaman Lal joined Punjab Police as DIG (Administration) in January 1985 and was assigned the task of revamping the state's police in the aftermath of Operation Blue Star. In April 1986, he was appointed DIG (Border) BSF at Gurdaspur, with oversight powers over Punjab Police to deal with the problem of terrorism in the border areas. On promotion, he joined Punjab Police as IGP (Border) which post he held from April 1988 to October 1988.

As DIG (Border) BSF and later as IGP (Border) Punjab Police, he extensively toured the rural areas of the three most adversely